

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 19 · 20 November 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

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BREAKING · TOTARA CRESCENT

Miniature Wooden Birdhouses Nailed To Power Poles, Council Says It's Not Their Problem

Case definition: any hand-built wooden birdhouse, roughly palm-sized, nailed (not screwed, nailed) to a power pole along Totara Crescent. Six confirmed as of Tuesday, each slightly more structurally ambitious than the last. Council's official position, delivered by a spokesperson who sounded genuinely delighted to say it, is that birdhouses on power poles fall outside every jurisdiction they're aware of and they intend to keep it that way. No bird has moved in yet. Everyone agrees it's only a matter of time.

Community Outbreak Bulletin

BUSINESS · MARKETS

A Position Closed Early, For Once, And I Regret Nothing

Sherman McCoy

Judy asked why I closed two days early this time instead of my usual stubbornness. I told her the number said what it needed to say by Tuesday, and waiting for Friday out of habit isn't conviction, it's ego. Marshall didn't even bother getting up from the door, which I've started reading as his own form of approval. I was right by Wednesday afternoon. I'd have been righter waiting. I don't regret it.

THE SILENT MAJORITY REPORT

On The Matter Of The Unmarked Ballot Box

Richard Nixon

The community noticeboard now hosts a small wooden box marked only "suggestions," no further instruction given, no results ever posted. I recognize the device. A box that collects opinions without ever being seen to act on them is not a suggestion box. It is a pressure release valve dressed as democracy, and I say that as a man who once tried something similar with slightly higher stakes and considerably worse results.



TECHNOLOGY · REALITY DISTORTION FIELD

The Yumicast, Reviewed Properly This Time

This week, a console three inches thinner than anything on the market started shipping. That is the plain fact. Everything about how you experience a living room just changed forever. For decades, humanity has been trapped by consoles the size of a toaster. Today, that ends. The Yumicast isn't a box under your television. It's a statement about what's possible when you stop asking permission to disappear into the furniture.

One correction, while I have the page. Last issue's Doki Doki Mon: Boba Pearl Edition reveal ran under a Yumicast masthead. It shouldn't have. Boba Pearl is a Nuntendo SameCube title, not ours, and I take full responsibility for a mistake that, frankly, should never have reached print. I checked this issue's Sonic The Bed Hog listing myself, twice, before it ran. It's ours. Insanely great.

Steve Jobs

WEATHER · EPIC FORECAST

The First Genuinely Cold Snap Since The Warm Stretch, Right On Schedule

Dana Foley

Told you not to trust it. Four days of warmth, and now a southerly change dropping the overnight low back into single digits, arriving with exactly the smugness I've come to expect from this time of year. Jacket back in rotation. I take no pleasure in being right about this one, mostly because being right about weather has never once made anyone thank me for it.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA · DID YOU KNOW?

Where Golden Boba's Colour Actually Comes From

Golden or champagne-coloured boba pearls usually get their colour from brown sugar syrup mixed directly into the tapioca starch before cooking, not from food dye added afterward.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"A box that collects opinions without ever being seen to act on them is not a suggestion box. It is a pressure release valve dressed as democracy."

— Richard Nixon, The Silent Majority Report

JOKE OF THE WEEK

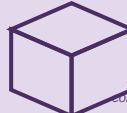
Why did the barista refuse to argue? They didn't want to stir up any trouble.



SONIC THE BED HOG

Gotta sleep fast.
Now on SEGA Yumicast

PARODY PLACEMENT · NOT A REAL SEGA OR SONIC AD



NUNTENDO SAMECUBE

Same shape. Different company. Totally unrelated.
Home of Doki Doki Mon: Boba Pearl Edition

PARODY PLACEMENT · NOT A REAL NINTENDO OR GAMECUBE AD



MARKETS · THE PEARL INDEX

The Loyalty App Migration, And What It Actually Cost In Repeat Visits

Fieldwork window: the three weeks since Bellevue Lane's counter swapped its paper punch card for the app-based system. Method: comparing weekly repeat-visit rates for the eight weeks before the swap against the three weeks since. Finding: repeat visits dropped 6% in the transition window (n=280, ±4.4% MOE), concentrated almost entirely among customers over fifty, based on informal counter observation I'll admit isn't rigorous enough to publish as data but is consistent enough to mention. Honest limitation: three weeks is thin, and a genuine transition dip is exactly what you'd expect regardless of whether the app succeeds long-term. I'll revisit this in two months, once the dip has had time to prove itself temporary or not.

Priya Anand, *The Pearl Index*



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

How Many Birdhouses Did Finn Spot?

Last issue's question, resolved: Kai didn't wait 8 minutes, and Theo waited exactly 2 minutes longer than Lena. Only Lena = 6, Theo = 8 clears both clues, leaving Kai at 4. Kai waited 4 minutes.

Three neighbours (Bea, Finn, Ola) each spotted a different number of Totara Crescent's birdhouses this week: 2, 4, 6.

1. Finn didn't spot 6.
2. Ola spotted exactly 2 more than Bea.

Brisk one this week · how many birdhouses did Finn spot? Answer next week — Ken Endo

MENACE WATCH

The Birdhouse Builder Of Totara Crescent: Hero Or Menace?

Six birdhouses now, each nailed under cover of darkness to a power pole along Totara Crescent, each slightly better built than the last. I do not find this reassuring. I find it, if anything, more calculated than an ordinary act of neighbourliness, because ordinary neighbourliness does not improve its craftsmanship week over week like it's building toward something. Who practices a skill in secret unless they intend to eventually need it at scale? My standing bounty remains: two hundred dollars and a lifetime pearl-milk-tea card for a clear photograph of whoever's doing the nailing. I will note, purely for the record, that the sixth birdhouse uses the exact same offcut timber as the fence repair currently underway outside the Totara Crescent counter. Coincidence, possibly. I remain vigilant regardless.

— Gordon Slate, *Editor-in-Chief*

MUSIC

A Debut Album That Knows Exactly What It's Trying To Prove

Rebecca Black

First albums usually spend half their runtime apologizing for existing. This one doesn't, confident in exactly the unfussy way a debut earns respect instead of demanding it. No filler track hiding behind a skit, no single trying too hard to justify the whole project's existence. I know what it's like to have one song define years of conversation before anyone let the rest of the work speak. This artist won't have that problem, and it shows in every choice on the record.

SPORT · READING THE WATER

A First-Half Read That Took Until The Second To Pay Off

T. Marlow

Their winger kept cutting inside a half-step later than the play actually called for, a tell I clocked in the first ten minutes and said nothing about, waiting to see if it was fatigue or design. Turned out to be fatigue, same as I thought, and by the hour mark their whole shape had started sagging on that side. Nobody in the box mentioned it until the goal came from exactly there. I'd already written it down.

Sebastian

The front hedge came in level this year, no lean, no gap where it always used to thin near the gate. Sebastian stood back from it longer than the job required, the way he does with anything that finally comes out right after enough seasons of it not quite managing to. He does not remember deciding to care this much about a hedge. He remembers, more precisely, that caring about it never actually stopped.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

My Friend And I Won't Apologize First

Horatio McCallister

"My friend and I had a falling out and neither of us will apologize first. How do we fix this?" Two ships waiting for the other to signal first will sit becalmed forever, lad. Somebody has to raise the flag, and it costs ye less than ye think to be the one who does. Pride's a fine cargo until it's the only thing left in the hold. Fair winds.

IN MEMORIAM

The Punch Card System, Fully Retired At Last

Skeletor

The last paper punch card in this district, held on to by a single stubborn counter long after every competitor moved on, was finally retired this week in favour of the app system everyone else adopted months ago. I confess nothing about the small stack of nearly-full cards now sitting, unredeemable, in a drawer that used to mean something. Mourn the card if sentiment moves you toward cardboard. Its replacement will track you more precisely than a card ever could, and I remain, as ever, professionally impressed by systems that outlive their own sentiment.

BOOKS · THE DUCKWORTH SCALE

A Sequel That Forgot Why Anyone Liked The First One

Daffy Duck

The original had restraint. This one has none, replacing every quiet character beat with a louder, dumber set piece, as if the author mistook volume for stakes. I have made that exact mistake personally, on stage, repeatedly, and I recognize the flop sweat underneath the bravado immediately. Th-th-that's not a compliment.

DOKI DOKI MON

Not rendered artwork — delivered as a structured four-panel description (no renderer available this session):

Panel 1. Wide shot, a clearing at dusk. The trainer stands at the tree line; Boba Pearl peeks out from behind their leg. Caption: "Three days since the reveal, and Boba Pearl still won't leave my side." **Panel 2.** Close on a rustling bush, two eyes glinting in the shadow: an unnamed wild creature, watching. **Panel 3.** Boba Pearl notices first, shell rattling in alarm. The trainer's hand moves toward a pearl-shaped device on their belt. **Panel 4.** The wild creature bolts before contact, leaving only a scatter of shed feather-like scales. Trainer, crouched, picking one up: "First one that's run from us instead of the other way around."

Doki Doki Mon — Bubble Tea News's syndicated cartoon slot, its first real encounter since the Issue 11 debut. Wholly original in-house IP; art to follow in a future issue.